

EMOTION COACHING FOR AGES 2-7

The Big Feelings Toolkit

A feelings chart, calm-down cards, a feelings thermometer and gentle words for the storm, to help little ones understand big emotions and find their calm.



Happy



Sad



Angry



Scared



Excited



Calm



Silly



Loved

Emotion coaching: a guide for grown-ups

Big feelings are a normal, healthy part of growing up. Young children are still learning how to handle them, and they learn it mostly from the grown-ups around them, by being helped through feelings again and again. Emotion coaching is a simple way to do that, in five steps.

1

Notice

Watch for the small signs before a storm: a wobbly lip, a tight body, a louder voice. Small feelings are easier to help with than huge ones. A feeling is a chance to connect, not a problem to fix fast.

2

Name it

Put simple words to what you see: "You look really frustrated. That tower keeps falling down." Naming a feeling helps children make sense of it and feel understood.

3

Validate

Let them know the feeling makes sense, even if the behavior isn't okay: "Of course you're sad. You were having so much fun." You can understand a feeling without agreeing or giving in.

4

Help calm

Stay close and stay as calm as you can. Children borrow our calm. Offer a hug, a slow breath, a quiet spot or a calm-down card. Save the talking for later.

5

Problem-solve together

Once everyone is calm, talk it through: What happened? What could we try next time? Keep limits clear and kind: all feelings are okay, but hurting people or things is not.

All feelings are okay. Not all behavior is.

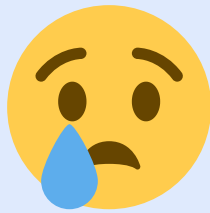
Look after yourself too. It's hard to stay calm when a child is upset. If you need to, take a slow breath or step back for a moment while keeping everyone safe. Nobody gets this right every time. When you lose your cool, coming back to say sorry and reconnect is a powerful lesson too (see **After the Storm**).

Feelings Chart

How do you feel right now? Point to the face that matches your feeling.



Happy



Sad



Angry



Scared



Worried



Excited



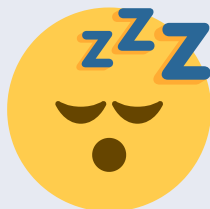
Calm



Frustrated



Silly



Tired



Surprised



Shy



Proud



Loved



Disappointed



Confused

How Big Is My Feeling?

Point to how big your feeling is. Start at the bottom and go up.

HOW BIG?	MY BODY MIGHT FEEL...	WHAT CAN HELP
5 Huge Explosive	 I might yell, cry, hit or run. I can't think. I need a grown-up to help me.	Stay safe. A grown-up stays close. Quiet, a hug, or my calm corner.
4 Big Boiling	 My heart beats fast. My fists or teeth squeeze tight. It's hard to listen.	Wall push, squeeze and release, or balloon breathing.
3 Medium Bubbling	 My face feels hot, or my tummy feels funny. I feel like whining or stomping.	Smell the flower, blow the candle. Tell a grown-up how I feel.
2 Small Wobbly	 Something is bugging me a little. I can still think and talk.	Say the feeling out loud. Take a sip of water.
1 Calm Cool	 My body feels loose and easy. I can play, listen and think.	Keep going! This is a great time to practice a calm-down card.
My feeling is a _____		

For grown-ups: teach the thermometer when your child is calm, using everyday examples ("A lost sock is a 2. A lost teddy might be a 4!"). At 4 or 5, thinking and talking are hard, so use fewer words and more calm presence. Clues and ideas are just examples; add your child's own.

Calm-Down Cards 1 of 2

< Cut along the dashed lines. Choose your favorites together and keep them in your calm corner.



Balloon breathing

1. Put your hands on your tummy.
2. Breathe in slowly. Fill your tummy like a balloon.
3. Breathe out slowly. Sssss... the balloon gets small.



Flower and candle

1. Hold up one finger.
2. Smell the flower: breathe in through your nose.
3. Blow out the candle: breathe out slowly.



Star breathing

1. Hold up your hand like a star.
2. Trace up a finger and breathe in.
3. Trace down and breathe out. Go all the way around.



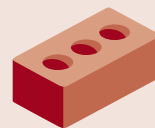
5-4-3-2-1

1. Find 5 things you can see.
2. 4 things you can touch, 3 you can hear.
3. 2 things you can smell, 1 you can taste.



Squeeze and let go

1. Squeeze your hands tight, like lemons.
2. Hold and count: 1, 2, 3.
3. Let go! Wiggle your floppy fingers. Do it again.



Wall push

1. Put both hands flat on a wall.
2. Push, push, push as hard as you can.
3. Count to 10. Then shake out your arms.